

Four marks walked, four names given – and in return, this. We had hoped to find our contact waiting. Instead: an envelope, and a scrap of paper folded inside it.

The carnival is louder here, and stranger. Carts roll toward the square that the men swear are loaded with fireworks for the feast – but the crates ride heavy, and the men guarding them are not laughing. Under the masks and the music, the whole city feels wound tight, like a string before it snaps.

MESENTERS,

Your contact is gone.

He left this note – enclosed – and nothing more. We do not know if he fled, was taken, or simply decided the risk was too great; though a contact who vanishes the same night the city arms itself is rarely a contact who chose to leave. What we know is that the letter still needs to reach its recipient before tonight.

You will have to find the way yourselves. But first – you were on the streets today. So were others. Here is what they were saying.

Overheard near the Old Town Square –

”The Council meets after dark, tells no one, decides for everyone. Secret, because it fears the light.”

A craftsman near the city wall –

”We give the men and the weapons. When it is over, the Council will still rule – not us.”

Two merchants, arguing by a cart –

”War comes, bread doubles in price. This is a lords’ quarrel, and the baker pays for it.”

Whispered at the inn –

”They say Bażyński is handing Prussia to the king in Kraków. Swapping one master for another.”

An old woman, shaking her head –

”Bażyński? His leg has gone stiff on him again – the great man can barely cross a room. And that is who means to bring down armoured knights.”

An old man at the gate –

”When it is done, some knight will walk away with all of Prussia in his pocket. The cities did the work; another takes the prize.”

NOW – FIND YOUR NEXT CONTACT.

Three people went into town this morning, and each bought one thing.

Work out who bought what, and where each of them works.

WHERE THEY WORK, AND WHAT IS MADE THERE: the Old Mill – bread; Piccolo – hot food, ladled out from a kitchen; the Smithy – horseshoes.

THE THREE: Kordian, Lambert, Jordan. WHAT WAS BOUGHT: food, a horseshoe, cloth.

Overheard this morning – and all of it true:

1. Lambert could have eaten at his own place, yet he went to buy his food elsewhere.
2. Jordan bought from the one who bought cloth.
3. The miller swears he bought nothing from Kordian.

Once you have placed Jordan, you will know where he works. Go there – and ask for him by name.

So we are on our own. A riddle to point us at a man, a man to point us onward, and the letter still heavy in the bag. Whoever R_c was, he is gone – we are not. Three people, three errands. Let us work it out.